the popular classes into a process that represented something more than co-optation, by fostering the conversion of many popular leaders. Far from any substantive transformation, a left arose, set on adapting popular sectors for capitalism: with experience in guiding popular organisations and entities, with the capacity to translate this experience into votes, the left took management positions in capitalist companies, in pension funds and in private bodies that took over the administration of privatised sections of what formerly had been universal entitlement. If the more durable political traditions in the subordinate countries did not disappear, many business groups sought to combine them with new forms of belief. Analysed in depth in the Brazilian case (cf. Neves 2005; Martins 2009; Coelho 2012), this phenomenon has its parallel in the extension of the national or international voluntary sector in the BRICS member-states.

In this optic, the entrance of new competing associated members and the volume of expropriations affecting unequally all types of workers involve serious difficulties. Centre country worker losses intensify and breed political and ideological utterances, which at times are translated into arguments that get close to extreme nationalism or fascism. Large popular mobilisations, whether in centre or peripheral countries, are ignored and do not result in effective political solutions, which leads to exasperation and to proof that the democratic sphere has been reduced to an electoral game between ever more similar candidates. An extremely complex and highly unpredictable social and political era is opened on the international level. Mass commitment to claims of equality (which democracy was supposed to secure) is seen as blocked, provoking a lack of confidence in political organisations, entities and institutions. Thus workers in centre or peripheral capital-imperialist countries find fewer and fewer ways of making their demands at a time when the international division of labour links them together more intensively.

Local bourgeoisies in middle-power countries and with consolidated states were able to expand, even though as subalterns and, strictly speaking, by continuing to be subaltern. The continuing crises in primary countries produce new impasses: on the one hand, the predominant country, the United States, propagates a capital-imperialist policy (democracy as social control without social rights, capture of popular social movements and their conversion into specialised managers, national compression of class struggles and so on); on the other hand, foreign direct investments (FDI) combined with local modes of value extraction as well as ruptures accomplished by public debts. In critical junctures, therefore, in the face of the fragility of worker bodies, leading capitalists and their states tend to return to the hardest and less 'interconnected' positions, voicing